The Financial Options Review Checklist

What to gather, write down and ask while you're paying for Mom's care.

Mom's care is paid from her accounts every month, and everyone seems to have a rule to offer about her savings. This list isn't about the care bill you're already paying. It's for the other decisions: before your family spends down, transfers money, changes ownership, sells something or buys a financial product, these are the things to have in hand. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something still to gather or ask, not a verdict on anything your family has done.

Gather

- [ ] The latest bill from Mom's care provider, and the agreement or contract that was signed with them.
- [ ] Statements for the accounts her care is paid from, and the receipts for what has been paid so far, small ones included. [1]
- [ ] Her insurance policies, any annuity contract and her latest retirement account statements: the papers themselves, not what someone remembers about them.
- [ ] The paperwork for any burial or funeral arrangement, if one has been made.

Write down

- [ ] What Mom's care costs each month, taken from the bill.
- [ ] What comes in for her each month, and which account pays the rest.
- [ ] Her outstanding debts and regular bills, and any home or personal expense that is coming up.
- [ ] Any gift, repayment, transfer, sale or change of name on an account that has already happened: what it was, who was involved, and the date as best you know it. [1]
- [ ] Any money decision the family is talking about, marked “being discussed”: a gift, a transfer, a sale, a financial product someone has suggested.
- [ ] What you've been told about what has to be spent or what should be moved, and who said each thing.

Ask

- [ ] Ask your Medicaid planner which of Mom's assets may be countable and which may not be, and which may already receive favorable treatment under the rules that apply to her.
- [ ] Ask whether any spend-down questions apply to Mom's situation and, if she is married, what the rules may mean for her spouse.
- [ ] Ask your Medicaid planner to look at everything on your “being discussed” list before anyone acts on it.
- [ ] Ask who else should review it: an elder law attorney for anything that needs legal review, and a licensed insurance or financial professional for a policy, an annuity or another product.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you gather, write down and ask. It doesn't say what has to be spent, how any asset is treated, or whether any gift, sale or purchase is a good idea. Rules vary by state, and those answers come from your Medicaid planner and the licensed professionals who know Mom's state and her situation. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to gather, what to write down and what to ask. The planning interview asks about the rest of your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner and to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow the record-keeping habits in the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people who manage money for a family member. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing Someone Else's Money: Help for agents under a power of attorney